

Databricks Data Engineer Associate

18-Day Study Plan • Exam: July 11, 2025 at 7:00 AM

Days until exam

18

July 11 • 7:00 AM

Current score

28 / 45

62% — need 71%

Target score

36+ / 45

80% — safe buffer

 DLT (priority 1)

 Delta Lake

 Architecture

 Jobs & SQL

 Spark SQL

 Practice

WEEK 1 — Jun 23-29 • Foundation & biggest gaps

Tue

Jun 23

Architecture deep dive

Architecture

- Watch freeCodeCamp @ 1:19:32 — Cluster Types (control plane vs data plane)
- Watch freeCodeCamp @ 1:51:53 — Databricks Web Application
- Key fact: driver/worker nodes live in the data plane; web app in control plane
- Read Lakehouse benefits section in Module 1 PDF

- [freeCodeCamp full course \(YouTube\)](#)
- [Module 1 PDF \(Databricks Workspace\)](#)

Wed

Jun 24

Delta Lake behavior

Delta Lake

- Watch freeCodeCamp @ 3:03:32 — Delta Lake deep dive
- Read Module 3 PDF — focus on overwrite, CTAS, and caching
- Key fact: external Parquet caching → convert to Delta; CTAS infers schema automatically
- Practice Q9, Q15, Q16, Q17 from the official practice exam PDF

- [freeCodeCamp full course \(YouTube\)](#)
- [Module 3 PDF \(Delta Lake\)](#)

Thu

Jun 25

DLT — syntax & pipeline creation

DLT

- Watch DLT Full Course — first 2 hours
- Key syntax: CREATE LIVE TABLE table_name AS SELECT ...
- DLT pipelines are created from the Jobs page — not Data or Compute
- Read Module 4 PDF pages on pipeline creation and syntax

- [Delta Live Tables Full Course \(YouTube\)](#)
- [Module 4 PDF \(Delta Live Tables\)](#)

Fri

Jun 26

DLT — expectations & streaming tables

DLT

- Continue DLT Full Course — hours 2-4
- Key fact: EXPECT constraint = records added but flagged in event log (not dropped by default)
- EXPECT (DROP ON VIOLATION) = records dropped; EXPECT (FAIL ON VIOLATION) = job fails
- Difference between STREAMING LIVE TABLE vs LIVE TABLE
- What DLT uniquely adds = dependency management (not scaling, not streaming)

■ [Databricks Declarative Pipelines Full Course \(YouTube\)](#)

■ [Module 4 PDF \(Delta Live Tables\)](#)

Sat

Jun 27

Spark SQL & Python syntax

Spark SQL

- Watch freeCodeCamp @ 5:04:23 — Spark DataFrame API
- Watch freeCodeCamp @ 5:15:53 — Tables and Views
- Key fact: struct field access = payload.date, not payload[date]
- Key fact: f-strings = f"{region}{store}_sales_{year}" — no + operators needed
- Practice Q20, Q21, Q24 from the exam

■ [freeCodeCamp full course \(YouTube\)](#)

■ [Module 2 PDF \(Transform Data with Spark\)](#)

Sun

Jun 28

Jobs, orchestration & SQL endpoints

Jobs & SQL

- Watch freeCodeCamp @ 6:49:58 — Jobs, Monitoring, Visualization
- Read Module 5 PDF — deploy workloads with Databricks Workflows
- Key facts: task-level retry (not job-level) to minimize compute; job config = JSON download
- SQL endpoint slow sequential queries → increase cluster size (not scaling range)
- Practice Q37, Q38, Q39, Q40 from the exam

■ [freeCodeCamp full course \(YouTube\)](#)

■ [Module 5 PDF \(Databricks Workflows\)](#)

Mon

Jun 29

First full mock exam — timed 90 min

Practice

- Take DatabricksCertifiedAssociateDataEngineerExam.pdf — all 45 questions, timed 90 min
- Score yourself and note every wrong answer by topic
- Do not look up answers until after scoring
- Target: 32+ (passing threshold). Flag any topic you miss 2+ times for Week 2

■ [Mock Exam PDF \(Amrit-Hub GitHub\)](#)

WEEK 2 — Jun 30 - Jul 6 • Reinforce & fill remaining gaps

Tue

Jun 30

Review mock exam misses

Practice

- Go through every wrong answer from Sunday's mock — read the full explanation
- Use ExamTopics community discussions to understand why the correct answer is right
- Re-read relevant Module PDFs for any topic missed more than twice

■ [ExamTopics — free practice questions with discussions](#)

Wed

Jul 1

Medallion architecture & streaming

Delta Lake

- Watch freeCodeCamp @ 5:39:38 — Structured Streaming
- Watch freeCodeCamp @ 5:44:42 — Auto Loader
- Bronze → Silver hop = enrichment/cleaning with writeStream + append mode
- Silver → Gold hop = aggregation with groupBy + complete output mode
- Practice Q29, Q30, Q31 from the exam

■ [freeCodeCamp full course \(YouTube\)](#)

Thu

Jul 2

DLT revision + Databricks SQL

DLT

- Re-watch freeCodeCamp @ 6:44:35 — Delta Live Tables section
- Watch official Databricks DLT explainer video
- Review Databricks SQL alerts, query scheduling, dashboard refresh (Q41, Q42, Q43)
- Key: schedule a query from the query's own page in DBSQL — not the Jobs UI

■ [Official Databricks DLT explainer \(YouTube\)](#)

■ [freeCodeCamp full course \(YouTube\)](#)

Fri

Jul 3

Unity Catalog, governance & permissions

Jobs & SQL

- Watch freeCodeCamp @ 6:55:54 — Unity Catalog and Access Control
- GRANT SELECT = read; GRANT ALL PRIVILEGES = full access; GRANT USAGE = can use DB
- Practice Q44, Q45 + ExamTopics governance questions
- Review Auto Loader: cloudFiles format enables Auto Loader (no separate format needed)

■ [freeCodeCamp full course \(YouTube\)](#)

■ [ExamTopics governance questions](#)

Sat

Jul 4

ExamTopics deep practice session

Practice

- Do 30+ questions on ExamTopics — focus on DLT, architecture, and Delta sections
- Read community discussion for every question you get wrong or are unsure about
- Note any new topic patterns that keep appearing

■ [ExamTopics — free practice questions](#)

■ [ITExams — additional free questions](#)

Sun
Jul 5

Second full mock exam — timed 90 min

Practice

- Retake the original official Databricks practice exam PDF (the one you already took)
- Strictly timed — 90 minutes, no notes
- Target: 38+ (you should be comfortably over 32 by now)
- Score and compare to your first attempt (28/45) — track improvement per topic

■ [Official Databricks Practice Exam PDF](#)

Mon
Jul 6

Weak topic blitz based on Jul 5 results

Practice

- Review every wrong answer from Jul 5 mock exam
- Re-read only the Module PDFs covering your remaining gaps
- Do a focused 20-question ExamTopics session on those specific topics only
- Rest after 3 hours — don't over-study

■ [Amrit-Hub full topic list & PDFs](#)

WEEK 3 — Jul 7-11 • Final polish & exam day

Tue
Jul 7

Rapid-fire key facts review

Practice

- Write out the 20 most important facts you've learned (DLT constraints, plane architecture, medallion hops)
- Do 20 ExamTopics questions — aim for 90%+ correct
- Work through the Amrit-Hub README topic list — answer each bullet from memory

■ [Amrit-Hub topic list](#)

■ [ExamTopics practice](#)

Wed
Jul 8

Final full mock — simulate exam conditions

Practice

- Use ITExams or ExamTopics for a fresh 45-question set — strictly 90 min, no help
- Target: 40+ correct
- Identify any last remaining weak spots — spend max 1 hour on those after
- After that, stop studying new material completely

■ [ITExams — free practice questions](#)

■ [ExamTopics practice](#)

Thu
Jul 9

Light review only — no new material

Rest

- Skim your personal key facts list — 30 minutes max
- Confirm exam login, time zone (7 AM), and environment are ready
- Make sure you have valid ID ready for proctoring
- Sleep well — this matters more than extra study hours

Fri

Jul 10

Rest day — brain consolidation

Rest

- No studying — seriously. Your brain consolidates knowledge during rest
- Light walk, good meal, early bedtime
- Glance at your key facts list once if it helps — then put it away
- Set your alarm for 6:00 AM for the 7:00 AM exam

Sat

Jul 11

EXAM DAY — Databricks Certified Data Engineer Associate

Exam 7AM

- Wake 6:00 AM — light breakfast, coffee, no last-minute cramming
- Log in 15 min early for proctoring setup and ID check
- Read every question fully before answering — eliminate wrong answers first
- Flag uncertain questions and revisit — 2 min per question average
- You need 32 correct. You've been hitting 38+ in practice. You've got this.

Key PDFs: [Module 3 \(Delta Lake\)](#) | [Module 4 \(Delta Live Tables\)](#) | [Module 5 \(Workflows\)](#) | [DatabricksCertifiedAssociateDataEngineerExam.pdf](#)
All PDFs available free at: github.com/Amrit-Hub/Databricks-Certified-Data-Engineer-Associate-Questions
Key YouTube: [freeCodeCamp full course \(7.5 hrs\)](#) | [DLT Full Course](#) | [Databricks Declarative Pipelines Full Course](#)